

Community Perceptions of Criminology Students as Future Police Officers

Introduction

Criminology students are widely associated with becoming police officers due to a strong, deeply embedded public linkage between Criminology education and law enforcement. Under Republic Act No. 11131, officially known as the Philippine Criminology Profession Act of 2018, the official scope of practice for registered criminologists extends significantly beyond traditional police service. The law explicitly encompasses diverse professional domains, including forensic science, document examination, ballistics, correctional administration, industrial security management, probation and parole supervision, crime research, and academic instruction in higher education institutions (HEIs) offering the Bachelor of Science in Criminology program.

Despite the comprehensive mandate of RA 11131, its application and integration across local colleges and universities in Dagupan City and surrounding municipalities in Pangasinan often face a disconnect between academic curriculum standards and public perception. Higher education institutions offering Criminology programs strictly align their curricula with the Commission on Higher Education (CHED) standards and RA 11131 mandates to prepare graduates for multi-faceted career pathways. However, public awareness and societal expectations remain heavily locked into a narrow stereotype that equates Criminology exclusively with policing.

This persistent public narrowness is heavily driven by complex societal, environmental, media, institutional, and psychological factors. Socially and environmentally, Criminology students in local Pangasinan communities are prominently recognized through visible uniform practices, community immersion projects, tactical drills, and neighborhood law-enforcement assistance activities. Media representation further reinforces this stereotype by portraying Criminology strictly as a stepping stone to the Philippine National Police (PNP). Psychologically, community members often associate Criminology education with authority, physical discipline, and crime deterrence rather than technical research or rehabilitation. While existing empirical research has extensively focused on the career preferences of Criminology students themselves, significantly less attention has been directed toward analyzing community-level understandings and the specific factors driving public occupational stereotypes.

Statement of the Problem

This study seeks to understand how adult community members in selected barangays perceive Criminology students in relation to becoming police officers.

Specifically, it seeks to answer the following questions:

1. How do community members perceive Criminology students as future police officers?
2. What specific factors and reasons—classified into social, environmental, media/informational, psychological, and institutional aspects—influence community members to associate Criminology students primarily with police work?
3. What is the extent of community members' awareness regarding the broader Criminology program and its alternative career paths (such as forensics, corrections, industrial security, and academia) under RA 11131?

Objectives of the Study

This study aims to explore community members' perceptions of Criminology students as future police officers. Furthermore, this study aims to identify and analyze the underlying social, environmental, psychological, and institutional factors and reasons behind the public's primary association of Criminology students with police work. Finally, this study aims to determine and evaluate the community members' level of awareness regarding the broader scope of the Criminology program, including its non-policing career pathways established under Republic Act No. 11131.

Significance of the Study

This study will directly benefit Criminology students, particularly those enrolled in higher education institutions in Dagupan City and across Pangasinan, as well as criminologists nationwide. It will provide them with critical insights into public expectations, societal stereotypes, and professional stigma, enabling them to better navigate their professional identity beyond traditional police work.

Furthermore, the findings will be highly valuable to Criminology educators, academic department heads, and university administrators across all higher education institutions offering the Criminology program in Dagupan City and Pangasinan, as well as administrative bodies nationwide. It will assist academic leaders in identifying critical gaps in public awareness, guiding institutional community-extension programs, and designing targeted public information campaigns to promote a broader, more accurate understanding of the criminologist profession under RA 11131.

Review of Related Literature (RRL)

Previous literature demonstrates a heavy inclination among Criminology students toward law enforcement careers. Empirical findings by Santos et al. (2020) revealed that over 75% of surveyed Criminology students enrolled in course programs with the primary intention of entering the Philippine National Police (PNP). Similarly, research by Garcia (2021) highlighted that media exposure, familial expectations, civil service job security, and perceived social prestige were the primary drivers pushing students into policing roles.

From an institutional standpoint, the enactment of Republic Act No. 11131 expanded the professional horizon for criminologists in the Philippines. According to Dela Cruz and Reyes (2019), RA 11131 legally codified non-policing specialization areas—such as questioned document examination, forensic ballistics, polygraphy, crime scene investigation, correctional administration, probation, parole, and security management—as equal pillars of the profession. Mendoza (2022) emphasized that higher education institutions in Pangasinan have progressively upgraded their curriculum and laboratory facilities to meet these multi-disciplinary standards.

Despite legislative advancements, public and community perceptions remain deeply anchored in occupational stereotypes. Perez and Ramos (2019) indicated that community members frequently equate Criminology solely with police work due to visible uniform practices, tactical marching in public spaces, and community immersion initiatives. Environmental exposure plays a critical role; as noted by Banal et al. (2020), constant visual cues of Criminology students performing traffic management or barangay patrols strongly reinforce the local belief that the degree is strictly a police preparatory course.

Psychological and media factors also shape societal attitudes. According to Fernandez and Torres (2021), public perception is heavily mediated by news broadcasts and television dramas that exclusively depict criminologists as active crime-fighters or PNP officers, largely ignoring behind-the-scenes forensic scientists or correctional officers. Furthermore, Aquino (2018) observed a psychological bias among community members, where authority, uniforms, and physical rigor are automatically mapped onto police roles.

Recent studies by Villanueva et al. (2022) in northern Luzon highlighted a pervasive lack of public awareness regarding civil employment opportunities in private industrial security, fire protection (BFP), jail management (BJMP), and academic research. Castro and Soriano (2023) argued that academic institutions must actively engage surrounding communities to dismantle these stereotypes. Similarly, Bautista (2020) stressed that community extension programs must highlight criminologists' forensic and rehabilitative capabilities.

Recent inquiries by Dizon and Ocampo (2023) confirmed that while students are increasingly exposed to forensic and correctional tracks, public perception lags due to institutional inertia in public communication. Lastly, Ramos and Mercado (2024) underscored that understanding local community perceptions in provincial hubs like Pangasinan is essential for closing the gap between statutory professional standards under RA 11131 and actual public understanding.

Methodology

Research Design

This study will employ a qualitative-descriptive research design utilizing a thematic analysis approach to examine community perceptions and underlying occupational stereotypes. A qualitative-descriptive design is appropriate as it allows the researchers to gather rich, detailed, and uncorrupted descriptions of human experiences and community perspectives without altering the natural setting. The thematic analysis approach will be utilized to systematically identify, analyze, organize, and report overarching themes and patterns from the qualitative data gathered during fieldwork.

Participants & Sampling Method

The participants for this study will consist of adult community members aged 18 years and above residing in selected barangays within the scope of Calasiao, Pangasinan. Participants will be chosen using a purposive sampling method based on specific inclusion criteria, including their residency status in the selected barangays, age eligibility, willingness to participate, and regular exposure to or familiarity with local Criminology students and educational institutions in the area.

Data Gathering & Analysis

Data will be gathered through face-to-face, semi-structured interviews guided by a pre-validated interview instrument. The researchers will seek informed consent and conduct audio-recorded interview sessions to capture the participants' nuanced perspectives on social, environmental, media, and psychological factors influencing their perceptions. Following the completion of field interviews, the recorded responses will be transcribed verbatim and subjected to thematic analysis following Braun and Clarke's framework to generate meaningful themes regarding public perceptions, societal factors, and awareness of RA 11131 career paths.

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